

Chapter 37: Returning Without Announcing It

Jenny didn't look up when the door opened.

She told herself it was coincidence.

Timing.

Routine.

Anything except expectation.

But her body already knew.

Austin had returned.

And the air shifted the moment he stepped inside.

She hated that she noticed it so quickly now.

"Good morning."

His voice reached her before she turned.

Calm.

Even.

Familiar in a way that felt unfair.

Jenny finally looked up.

"...Morning."

A pause.

"You're early," she added.

Austin nodded once.

"I wanted to come before service started."

Jenny frowned slightly.

"Why?"

He didn't answer immediately.

Instead, he looked at her.

Not in observation mode.

Not analyzing.

Just... present.

Then—

"I didn't like being away longer than I expected."

That made her pause.

She tightened her grip on the counter cloth.

"...It was one day."

"Yes."

Silence.

Then Austin added quietly,

"That felt longer than it should have."

Jenny looked away immediately.

Of course she did.

The restaurant slowly filled.

Noise returned.

Movement returned.

Normality returned.

But Jenny didn't fully return to it.

Not anymore.

Because now she was aware of him again.

Not as absence.

But as presence.

Which somehow felt more disruptive.

At one point, she walked past table seven.

Austin was sitting there.

Watching nothing in particular.

Waiting in a way that didn't feel like waiting anymore.

It felt like staying.

Jenny slowed slightly without meaning to.

Austin noticed immediately.

Of course he did.

"You're distracted," he said when she reached him.

"I'm working."

"You always say that when something is bothering you."

Jenny sighed.

"You keep saying that like you understand me completely."

"I don't," he said.

"But I understand patterns."

That word again.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"I'm not a pattern."

"No," he agreed.

"You're not."

A pause.

Then softer—

"But your reactions are."

That made her stop.

"...Excuse me?"

Austin leaned slightly forward.

"You pull away when something becomes unfamiliar."

Jenny frowned.

"That's not true."

"It is," he said calmly.

"And then you return when it becomes stable again."

Silence.

Jenny felt something tighten in her chest.

"I don't like being analyzed," she said quietly.

"I know," Austin replied.

"I'm not analyzing you to reduce you."

A pause.

"I'm trying to understand how to not lose you."

That sentence landed differently.

Not dramatic.

Not emotional.

Just direct.

Too direct.

Jenny looked away first.

Of course she did.

Later, when things slowed, Austin stayed seated longer than usual.

Jenny noticed.

Of course she did.

But she didn't comment.

Instead, she approached him anyway.

"You were gone yesterday," she said.

"Yes."

"Work?"

"Yes."

A pause.

Jenny hesitated.

"...Was she there?"

Austin looked at her immediately.

"Victoria?"

Jenny nodded slightly.

"Yes."

A pause.

Then—

“No.”

That answer should have been simple.

But Jenny didn’t relax.

Instead, she frowned.

“...You answered that too quickly.”

Austin tilted his head slightly.

“It’s the truth.”

Jenny crossed her arms.

“I don’t know why I care.”

That was a lie.

And they both knew it.

Austin didn’t call it out immediately.

He rarely did now.

Instead, he said quietly,

“You care because you’re trying to understand your place in this.”

That made her go still.

Jenny lowered her voice.

“I don’t even know what ‘this’ is anymore.”

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then—

"It's not undefined to me."

Jenny frowned.

"What is it to you?"

A pause.

Then simply—

"You."

Silence.

That word again.

Not relationship.

Not love.

Not label.

Just her.

Jenny felt her breath catch slightly.

She looked away immediately.

Of course she did.

But this time...

she didn't step back.

Austin stood slowly.

"I have to go soon."

Jenny nodded quickly.

"Okay."

But he didn't leave immediately.

Instead, he added quietly,

"You looked different yesterday when I wasn't here."

Jenny froze slightly.

"...Different how?"

A pause.

Then—

"Unsettled."

That word stayed in the air longer than it should have.

Jenny looked at him.

"I was fine."

Austin shook his head slightly.

"No."

A beat.

Then softer—

"You weren't."

Silence.

Jenny didn't argue.

Not this time.

Because part of her already knew he was right.

When he finally left, he didn't linger at the door like before.

No dramatic pause.

No extended stare.

Just movement.

But Jenny noticed something new.

He didn't leave like someone stepping out anymore.

He left like someone who knew he would come back without needing to prove it.

And somehow...

that certainty scared her more than his absence ever did.